

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN HONDURAS

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide uses the Honduran terms and bodies you'll actually run into — the environmental licence and MiAmbiente, free, prior and informed consultation, the amparo, protected-area boundaries, the Inter-American human-rights system, and the international financiers who back these projects — and explains each in plain words the first time. In Honduras, opposing a powerful project can cost your freedom or your life, so this guide puts your safety above everything.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The **Gualcarque River** is sacred to the **Lenca** people of Río Blanco. When a Honduran company, **DESA**, began building the **Agua Zarca dam** on it — without the consultation the law requires — the Lenca and their organisation, **COPINH**, resisted for years. Their leader, **Berta Cáceres**, a Goldman Prize winner, led the fight. And on **3 March 2016 she was assassinated in her home** — a murder a court later found was **ordered by DESA's executives** to remove the obstacle to their dam. That is the terrible half of this story, and it must be said first: in Honduras, this fight can cost your life. But hold the other half, equally true and hard-won. The killing did not build the dam — it doomed it. Under a storm of international solidarity, the dam's financiers — the Dutch bank **FMO**, Finland's **Finnfund**, and the **Central American Bank (CABEI)** — and the German firms **Voith and Siemens** all **withdrew, and construction was suspended**. And in 2021 **DESA's former president, David Castillo, was convicted** of ordering Berta's murder, and sentenced to over 22 years. A dam was stopped, and its architects held to account — at the highest imaginable cost.

Hear the danger plainly, because it shapes every choice in this guide. Honduras is among the deadliest countries on Earth to defend land and water. Defenders have been criminalised and jailed on charges a UN body found arbitrary; defenders have been killed — Berta Cáceres in 2016, the COPINH activist Nelson García days later, the Tocoa water defender **Juan López** in 2024. The violence comes from the state, from companies, from local power-holders, and from organised crime, often entangled, and those who order it usually enjoy impunity. This does not mean nothing can be done. It means that **how** you organise — collectively, never alone; visibly, with witnesses; and with protection sought early — matters as much as what you do.

There is real, hard-won hope. The **Guapinol water defenders**, criminalised and jailed for opposing a mine in a national park, were freed after a national and international campaign, and the shrinking of their park for mining was challenged and, on paper, reversed. A reformist government declared Honduras free of new open-pit mining. These wins were forged by organised communities — often Lenca, Garífuna, Tolupán, and Miskito peoples and campesino movements — using their rights, their courage, and powerful international solidarity.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Honduran project needs its **environmental licence**; on Indigenous or Afro-descendant land it needs **free, prior and informed consultation**; it needs land, water, mining, or energy **concessions**, some needing

congressional or municipal approval; and — distinctively — it usually needs **money from financiers who can be made to withdraw**. Every one of those is a link you can grab. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — and protect your people above all.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation — safety absolutely first:

- **If financiers or foreign companies back it, that is often the decisive lever** — Agua Zarca's funders and builders all withdrew.
- **If Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples were not consulted, or the licence was fraudulent, or a protected area was unlawfully shrunk, the project is legally exposed** — and the Inter-American system gives you scrutiny the domestic system won't.
- **A reformist opening — a mining moratorium, a protected-area restoration — gives you something concrete to demand be enforced.**
- **The danger is lethal** — defenders have been jailed and killed, so organise collectively and visibly, seek protection early, and never act alone.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **use the external levers** — international solidarity, the financiers, and the Inter-American system, which are live and powerful here — and **combine the strands** safely: the documents, the consultation and licence, the concessions, the courts, the financier campaign, the press. That combination, kept safe, is how these fights are won.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The environmental gate is the **environmental licence**, granted through the national impact-assessment system run by **MiAmbiente** (the environment secretariat). **Congress and municipalities** approve various land, water, mining, and energy concessions. On Indigenous or Afro-descendant land, **free, prior and informed consultation** is required in law (Honduras ratified **ILO Convention 169** in 1994). The **courts** review it all — and, decisively, **financiers and the Inter-American human-rights system** sit outside the captured domestic system. Know which decision you can reach — and remember the money and the international scrutiny are often your strongest points.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The environmental licence. The developer's assessment goes to MiAmbiente. *Your opening — and it arms every later step:* obtain it and expose a defective or fraudulent assessment.

Consultation and concessions. Indigenous consultation and congressional/municipal concessions. *Your opening:* a skipped or falsified consultation, or a protected area unlawfully shrunk, is a strong ground.

Financing. The project needs money. *Your opening — often the decisive one:* the financiers can be made to withdraw.

Construction. *Your opening:* the courts, the Inter-American system, and — above all — protection for your people.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — and, crucially, **who is financing and building it** (Agua Zarca's Dutch, Finnish, and Central American funders and its German builders all became the campaign's targets). **What it still needs** — the licence not final, consultation not done, financing not closed: whatever's missing is the soft spot. **Who's paying** — development banks, foreign firms, and investors with human-rights commitments they can be held to.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena — used carefully. **MiAmbiente** grants the licence. **Congress and municipalities** hold concessions. The **courts** review decisions and can convict those who kill defenders (as they convicted Castillo). The **financiers** have their own human-rights standards. The **Inter-American Commission and Court** grant **protective measures** and scrutiny. And Honduras's **Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples, campesino movements, and powerful international solidarity networks** are the forces that reach furthest — the combination that stopped Agua Zarca. But all of this operates amid lethal danger; protect people above all.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether financiers or foreign firms back it, whether consultation was skipped or a park unlawfully shrunk, whether the Inter-American system engages — and, always, the danger.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents (safely)	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Exposing a defective/fraudulent licence	15–35%	during licensing	low	Licence questioned or annulled
Skipped consultation / unlawfully shrunk park	25–50%	months–yr	low	Project legally exposed; reversed on paper
Amparo / courts	20–45%	1–3 yr	low	Decision examined; accountability
Inter-American protective measures / scrutiny	25–50%	months–yr	low	Protection; international pressure
Financier / foreign-company withdrawal	30–55%	months–yr	low	Funding pulled; project suspended (Agua Zarca)
Enforcing a reformist opening (moratorium, park)	20–45%	months–yr	low	A concession blocked; a park restored
Everything together (financiers, world watching)	35–60%	1–3 yr	low, risky	Suspended, reversed, defunded, protected
Everything together (state/crime-backed, closed)	15–35%	years	low, dangerous	Delayed, exposed — protect people first

The levers that move the needle most are **financier and foreign-company withdrawal**, the **Inter-American system**, and the **skipped-consultation / unlawful-park grounds**, backed by international solidarity. Agua Zarca shows the ceiling (a dam stopped, its architects convicted) and the terrible cost (lives lost). So aim for a defunded, suspended, or reversed project — and protect your people above every outcome.

On cost and safety: organising, documenting, and Inter-American petitions are low-cost, and international networks bring the financier campaigns and legal support. But this is among the deadliest places on Earth to resist — organise collectively, never alone; visibly, with witnesses; seek Inter-American protective measures early; and route every risk through lawyers and international allies.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this licence, this skipped consultation, this financier — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, safely.

- 1. What is it, and who's behind it — and who is financing and building it?** Name the project, the company, its owners, and — crucially — its financiers and foreign firms.
- 2. Where is it, and who does it affect?** Get the footprint and lay it over **Indigenous and Afro-descendant territory**, rivers and water, **protected areas** (and any that were quietly shrunk), farmland, coast, communities. **Indigenous/Afro-descendant land, sacred rivers, and protected areas are your sharpest levers**, so this map matters — Agua Zarca turned on a sacred river and a people never consulted.
- 3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is the licence granted? Consultation skipped? Financing not yet closed? These openings are time-bound — and financing is a live target until it closes.
- 4. What does it still need that it lacks?** A licence not final, consultation not done, a concession not approved, financing not closed. The missing piece — often the money — is the soft spot.
- 5. Who else is affected, and who already opposes it?** Neighbouring communities, Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples, campesino movements, international solidarity networks. Río Blanco's Lenca united with the world.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a dam or mine is planned on its river or in its park, with no consultation and foreign financing. The five questions yield: a company (and its financiers and builders) behind it; a site on Indigenous land, a sacred river, or a shrunk park (the sharp levers); a licence granted without consultation; financing not yet secured; and a coalition of communities and international allies. That's the Agua Zarca pattern — expose the skipped consultation, target the financiers, engage the Inter-American system, and protect your people.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — gathered **safely**. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the decisions rest on — the environmental assessment and licence, any consultation records (or the falsified "consent" that was used at Agua Zarca), the concessions, the protected-area boundaries (and any redrawing), and the **financing** arrangements. Then read them hard for flaws — a defective or fraudulent assessment, a skipped or faked consultation, a park unlawfully shrunk,

a concession granted without required approval.

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the site, the river, the land, the park — baseline evidence most of all — and, carefully, the testimony of affected residents and Indigenous authorities. In this lethal context, weigh the risk to anyone documenting.

Layer three: the map of peoples, rivers, parks, and financiers. Lay the project over the Indigenous and Afro-descendant land, the sacred rivers, and the protected areas — and map the **financiers and foreign firms**, the pressure points. This feeds the legal case, the Inter-American petition, and the financier campaign.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The environmental assessment and licence, the consultation records (or their absence/falsification), the concessions, the protected-area boundaries, the financing** — from MiAmbiente, Congress, municipalities, and public filings (8A).
- **Evidence of the affected peoples and any protected-area change** — from the communities' authorities and the protected-area records.
- **Financiers and foreign firms** — the banks, development finance institutions, and companies backing the project.
- **The peoples-rivers-parks-financiers map** — the land, rivers, parks, and money, laid over the site.
- **Dated evidence and consented testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, gathered so no one is put at risk.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; people give you power — and Río Blanco's Lenca, with the world behind them, are the example. Build it **safely, collectively, and never alone**. Four moves.

Start with a tight, trusted core. The community members most affected, the people who know the land and river, a few tireless organisers, and respected Indigenous, Afro-descendant, and community authorities — people you trust.

Centre the affected peoples and build the widest coalition. Where Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples are affected, their authorities and organisations (like COPINH) hold the strongest ground. Build the campaign around supporting that leadership, at their direction, and link to campesino movements and neighbouring communities.

Reach international solidarity — early and deliberately. This is Honduras's distinctive strength: international networks bring the financier campaigns, the Inter-American petitions, legal support, and — crucially — a measure of protection through visibility. Reach them early.

Bring in lawyers — and seek protection above all. Public-interest lawyers who run amparo and Inter-American cases, and — first of all — **Inter-American protective measures** for those at risk. Defenders have been jailed and killed; keep everything lawful and collective, protect the vulnerable, and route every threat through lawyers and international allies.

Build to last, and defend the win. Honduran fights run for years and cost dearly. Build clear roles, a secure archive, careful communications, a way to decide together, a serious safety plan, and a plan to defend a win

— Agua Zarca's stoppage, like the Guapinol park reversal, must be held.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES, CONSULTATION, FINANCIERS & THE INTER-AMERICAN SYSTEM

Law and money are real Honduran levers — but the external ones are the strongest, and safety comes first.

Expose the Licence and the Skipped Consultation

Everything downstream is stronger if you obtained the environmental licence and exposed a **defective or fraudulent assessment**, and — where Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples are affected — the **skipped or falsified free, prior and informed consultation** (ILO 169). A protected area unlawfully shrunk for the project is a further strong ground.

The Financiers — Often the Decisive Lever

Honduras's most distinctive lever: these projects usually depend on **financiers and foreign firms** with their own human-rights commitments, and a campaign can make them **withdraw**. Agua Zarca's Dutch, Finnish, and Central American funders and its German builders all pulled out under international pressure, and construction was suspended. Map the money and campaign — with international allies — on the financiers' own standards.

The Inter-American System and the Courts

Where the domestic system is captured, the **Inter-American Commission and Court** provide scrutiny and, vitally, **protective measures** for defenders at risk — seek these early. Domestically, the **amparo** and the courts can examine an unlawful licence, and — as with Castillo — can convict those who kill defenders.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the financiers, the Inter-American system, and the consultation grounds are real and powerful, but the domestic system is captured, the courts are compromised in politically sensitive matters, and — the gravest limit — resistance is lethal. So use the strong tools — the licence and consultation grounds, the financier campaign, the Inter-American system, the courts — protect your people above all, seek protective measures early, and count a defunded, suspended, or reversed project, accountability, and protection as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A financier becomes the lever. Not just "the dam is bad" but *"your institution funds a project imposed without consultation, where defenders are being attacked — your own standards require you to withdraw,"* as Agua Zarca's funders did.

A skipped consultation becomes an exposure. *"This affects our people and no free, prior and informed consultation was held — the project is illegal."*

A shrunk park becomes an unlawful act. *"This protected area was quietly redrawn to fit the project — unlawfully."*

The harm becomes an international story. *"The sacred river, the land, the lives already lost — for a project imposed on us and funded from abroad."*

Match it to the venue: the licence and consultation to MiAmbiente and the courts; the financing to the financiers on their own standards; the danger to the Inter-American system for protection; the human story to the international press.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Honduras, international attention protects people and reaches financiers — Agua Zarca became a global cause — but the domestic context is lethal, so handle media with care.

Lead with people and place, not procedure. Not "the assessment was defective" but "the sacred river, the land, the lives already lost — for a project imposed on us and funded from abroad." Use your strongest material: dated evidence, the map of the peoples and the money, and — carefully — Indigenous and Afro-descendant voices, without exposing anyone further.

Work several audiences at once — reach the financiers and the world. National press builds pressure; international media and solidarity networks reach the financiers, the Inter-American system, and the protection that visibility brings. Make it easy: captioned evidence, accurate summaries, a map, careful voices — and let the affected peoples lead the telling of their own story.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And protect people above everything — visibility can be a shield, but weigh every public act for safety.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them factual and calm; keep copies safely; and protect anyone at risk.

8A — Request for the licence and records (to MiAmbiente).

Subject: Solicitud de información — [proyecto].

"We, residents of [place], request the environmental assessment and licence, the consultation records, the concessions, and the protected-area boundaries for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection / exposing the skipped consultation.

Subject: Oposición — [proyecto].

"We, residents of [place] and [the Indigenous/Afro-descendant people], object to [project]: [no free, prior and informed consultation was held; the assessment is fraudulent; a protected area was unlawfully shrunk]. We ask that the licence be revoked. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To a financier or foreign firm.

Subject: Human-rights and legal risk in [project].

"We understand your institution [funds / builds] [project] at [location], imposed without consultation and amid attacks on defenders. Your own human-rights standards require you to reconsider — as FMO, Finnfund, CABEL, Voith, and Siemens did at Agua Zarca. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8D — To the Inter-American system (protection + petition).

Subject: Request for protective measures — [community], Honduras.

"We, defenders of [place], face [threats/criminalisation] for opposing [project], imposed without consultation. We request protective measures and ask the Commission to examine the case. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To a human-rights organisation / lawyer (amparo).

Subject: Legal support and amparo — [proyecto].

"Our community faces [project], licensed without consultation / on an unlawfully shrunk park. We've gathered [the licence, the record, photographs] and ask for legal support and, if warranted, an amparo — and, first, protection. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — Enforcing a reformist opening.

Subject: [Mining moratorium / protected-area restoration] and [project].

"We understand [project] at [location] conflicts with [the mining moratorium / the restored protected area]. We ask that this commitment be enforced against it. [Attach evidence.]"

8G — Letter to the international press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect [river / land / park] from [project].

"For generations the [people] of [place] have lived from [the river / the land] at [location]. Now [project] threatens it — imposed without our consent and funded from abroad, and our defenders are at risk. We can provide evidence, a map — and, carefully, interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the community (safely).

Subject: We can stop this — here's how, safely.

"[Project] threatens [our river / land / park]. The Lenca of Río Blanco stopped the Agua Zarca dam — its funders and builders withdrew, and those who killed Berta Cáceres were convicted — through international solidarity and courage. Through the financiers, the Inter-American system, and our unity, we have a real chance — protecting one another above all, never acting alone. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order, and safely:

- 1. Nail down the project, and above all its financiers and foreign builders.** The money is often the decisive, reachable lever.
- 2. Seek Inter-American protective measures for anyone at risk (8D) — first, before anything.**
- 3. Expose the skipped consultation, the fraudulent licence, or the shrunk park (8B).**
- 4. Request the documents (8A) safely.**

5. **Campaign on the financiers' own human-rights standards, with international allies (8C).**

6. **Reach international solidarity and the press, and organise collectively, never alone (8G/8H).** Agua Zarca was stopped this way.

Even lean, those six protect your people, hit the financiers, and connect you to the international leverage that works here.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Honduras's domestic system is captured and violent, so the field is severely tilted — plan for it, safety first.

When the state, companies, and crime are entangled. Lean on the **external** levers — the financiers, the Inter-American system, international solidarity — which are live and powerful here, and protect your people above all.

When defenders are criminalised or killed. This is the gravest danger. Seek Inter-American protective measures early, organise collectively and visibly, keep everything lawful, and route every threat through lawyers and international allies. The Guapinol defenders were freed by exactly this combination.

When a protected area is quietly shrunk. Document the redrawing — it is often unlawful and reversible, as the Guapinol park change was on paper.

When a reformist opening exists. A mining moratorium or a park restoration is something concrete to demand be enforced against your project.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Honduras has severe, documented capture of licensing, concessions, and the courts, and lethal violence against defenders, so this matters — approach it with the utmost care.

How to spot it. Licences on fraudulent assessments; falsified "consent"; parks redrawn for concessions; concessions steered to the connected; and defenders criminalised or killed to clear the way.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Domestically, oversight is weak and often compromised. The strongest checks are **external**: the **Inter-American Commission and Court**, international **financiers' accountability mechanisms**, and international solidarity and press. Where they function, the domestic **courts** can convict (as they did Castillo).

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the process was bent, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Do not make public accusations you can't back; here they can be fatal. Route serious evidence to the Inter-American system, financiers' mechanisms, trusted lawyers, and international press, protect witnesses above all, and pair exposure with the financier campaign.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, safely. The documents build your proof; pinning down the peoples, parks, and financiers aims it; the widest coalition and international solidarity build the power; the financier campaign and the Inter-American system press it; protection keeps your people alive. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and defend the win.

Early on (weeks 1–8): nail down the project, its footprint, its financiers; seek Inter-American protective measures for anyone at risk; expose the skipped consultation, the fraudulent licence, or the shrunk park; request the records safely; centre the affected peoples and reach international solidarity and a lawyer.

In the thick of it (months–years): campaign on the financiers; engage the Inter-American system; bring an amparo or court challenge; demand enforcement of any reformist opening; open the international media front.

The long haul (years): carry the cases and the financier campaign through; keep the coalition, the protection, and the attention alive; hold the line for a defunded, suspended, or reversed project, accountability, and protection — keeping your people safe throughout.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Honduras can be done — the Lenca of Río Blanco stopped the Agua Zarca dam, its funders and builders withdrew, and those who murdered Berta Cáceres were convicted. Hold both truths, and never forget the cost: Berta Cáceres, Nelson García, Juan López, and others were killed for this fight. Honduras's tools include unusually powerful **external** levers: international solidarity; financiers and foreign firms who can be made to withdraw; and the Inter-American system, which offers scrutiny and protection the captured domestic system will not. And the constraints are grave: a captured, violent system, compromised courts, and lethal danger to those who resist.

Here's the discipline that wins, and it stays collective, visible, and safe. Nail down the financiers and foreign builders — often the decisive, reachable lever. Seek Inter-American protective measures for anyone at risk, first of all. Expose the skipped consultation, the fraudulent licence, the unlawfully shrunk park. Campaign on the financiers' own human-rights standards, engage the Inter-American system, and demand enforcement of any reformist opening. Reach international solidarity, and organise collectively, never alone. Count a defunded, suspended, or reversed project, accountability, and — above all — the safety of your people as wins. That's what Río Blanco did — their courage, the financiers' withdrawal, and the world's solidarity together — and the lives it cost are the reason your first and last duty is to protect one another. So can you — collectively, visibly, and safely.